

The Controversy over Faith and Knowledge

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INTRODUCTION

[1]

In the Preface to my *Samlede Skrifter* it was remarked that the edition would not include everything I had published in the course of my life. Even so, it grew far more extensive than the original estimate had promised, and included, among other things, besides pieces collected earlier, 1200 pages that had not yet been published in book form.

Left out was everything polemical in form, everything that was not immediately accessible to the reader, and a multitude of shorter articles whose inclusion would have made the work swell far too much.

An author is badly placed, however, if he does not himself collect and take care of whatever — regardless of its greater or lesser worth — bears the stamp of his cast of mind. For, as experience shows, what he himself lets slip out of his hands, other hands seize upon. Once a writer has succeeded in making his name sufficiently known, strange fingers rummage in his literary life and present it in whatever way their presumed superiority sees fit. And this superiority has all the freer play, the more he has left to its caprice.

This consideration has led me to publish a supplement to my *Samlede Skrifter*, and I open this first supplementary volume with my earliest polemical articles, to be followed [2] by a selection of others, mixed with works that aim only to present and to instruct. As regards these earliest articles, and the few barbs they contain against certain distinguished authors such as Professors Høffding and Wilckens, whose goodwill is an honor that I cannot be suspected of wishing to forfeit, and whom I would therefore least of all wish to offend, I may be permitted to recall the fine letter from J. L. Heiberg to Carsten Hauch (28 January 1841), in which the former, after warmly accepting Hauch's outstretched hand and assuring him that an old feud between them has not left a spark of ill will in his mind, tells him that a reprint of some polemical articles from that time "can and should in no way disturb the good relationship" which, to his joy, now exists between them: "I know well that this renewal of what one might in one respect wish forgotten is easily misunderstood". But, he says, "it exists, after all, and in literature as well as in political history not only can facts not be altered, but it is even a duty to collect and preserve them." I do not go quite as far as J. L. Heiberg. Many polemical particulars are best consigned to oblivion, and it would not occur to me, e.g., to reprint my polemical sallies from the Nietzsche controversy of 1889–90, now that Høffding has left his out of the collection *Mindre Arbejder*. But to some of the literary feuds in which I have been

entangled people will perhaps return in the future. Much that now seems to have only historical interest may, when kindred phenomena arise again, become topical once more.

Faced with a critical author, the reading public divides into two groups: a larger one, which reads him if it is interested in the subjects he treats, and a smaller one, which is interested in the author himself. In the *Samlede Skrifter*, as was expressly stated in [3] the Preface, the whole emphasis was laid on the subject matter. Regard for the general public's need for instruction was the one deciding factor there. What belonged together by the nature of its subject was never split apart, even if it had been produced at widely separated times. And nothing was included that could lay claim to any attention only by its manner of treatment.

In the Supplement, however, there should also be room for this and that which can hold only those who already take an interest in the writer and who read him even when the subject he treats is a matter of indifference to them. The critical portrayal of a personality is, after all, an art in its own right, and can be judged much as portrait painting is, without regard to whether the reader or the viewer knows the subject or not. The art of fencing in intellectual disputes is likewise a small art of its own, and can amuse the reader as a fencing bout can entertain the spectator, without regard to the prize for which the fencers fight.

In other words, besides the broader reading public that seeks information about the subject matter, there is also a more finely developed public, which is drawn more by the author's personality than by the subject on which it happens for the moment to dwell. It is to this public that the supplementary volume is addressed.

April 1903.

G. B.

[4]

THE CONTROVERSY OVER FAITH AND KNOWLEDGE [5]

[6]

[7]

A. C. Larsen: Samvittighed og Videnskab

[Conscience and Science]

(1866)

Writings of philosophical content are in general not especially suited to review in a daily paper, and if some enthusiastic man now and then ventures the attempt, it easily turns out, as experience shows, to be a “scientific work of poetry” in the style of Lieutenant v. Buddinge. Since learned critiques are rightly regarded as inadmissible, the result is that on scientific subjects our papers teem with extremely brief, unproven and often enough unprovable assertions, which the public has indeed acquired a true virtuosity in swallowing quite raw, but whose number no sensible person can nevertheless feel any desire to increase. There is thus not much to invite one to review a pamphlet that does not belong to light literature; but since this one treats, with more than ordinary ability, a matter that not only has a claim on wide interest but has long since laid hold of it, the circle of readers the pamphlet may expect ought to be made aware of its appearance.

It contains a fundamental theological outlook, set forth partly in the form of communication, but more often by way of defense and attack, and as a scientific confession it is of particular interest, since the author possesses a philosophical cultivation that is becoming rarer and rarer among the theologians of the present day, and that helps him past the first reefs, on which the majority, with sublime composure, sit stuck fast in a common shipwreck.

Although the book is at feud with living persons in only a few places, it will nonetheless probably be regarded as a polemic, and Mr. *Larsen* will himself bear part of the [8] blame, since in a preface he has laid particular stress on his offensive aim. The part of the book that is of immediate interest is, moreover, the best, and one must be grateful to the author for having had the courage and the will to embark on a discussion of the boundary questions concerning the mutual relation between faith and knowledge, on which a clear and illuminating word is so seldom heard; among the students, the need to have these questions answered has long since pushed back every other need for philosophical learning, and not one of the internal tasks of science lies half so close to their hearts as this boundary dispute. Several, to be sure, have come to rest, but mostly those who would feel entirely satisfied with any conciliatory solution whatever; it is only human, after all, to want to have it both in the bag and in the sack, and natural

that one is then not too particular about whether the bread in the bag is honest bread or not. But far greater is the number of *those* who, after the lapse of a few years, have retained hardly any impressions of Professor *Nielsen's* brilliant and fruitful teaching other than those bearing on the difficulties mentioned, and for whom these questions are still and always burning. This state of affairs is neither good nor healthy, all the more so as those impressions are never quite clear. For in Professor Nielsen's philosophy, which still unfolds luxuriantly before the students' eyes, this point is, in the strict sense, the salient point, the real "unrest" that set the movement of thought going, drove the problems forward and kept the gifted worker from seeking rest for a single moment in rigidified forms. But it has seemed as though it were a condition of the life of the whole that this innermost provoking question should be kept constantly open, that the wound should not close where the thinker had been most deeply wounded by the god. Not that no answer was given; but the answer is better suited to calling forth new questions than to silencing those already raised.

Already in the Professor's *Propædeutik* of 1857 the sections that treat the relation in question contain a plain self-contradiction: they let faith and knowledge, though "absolutely heterogeneous principles", be reconciled in one consciousness, since the conflict between them "does not arise from what pertains to principle", and this contradiction has not since been removed. Professor Nielsen's position here is altogether such that he can expect to find two kinds of opponents: first, those who defend the existing theology, and secondly, those who attack it at its root and ground. The former will go after Prof. [9] Nielsen as the assailant of theology; the latter, who seek to overthrow theology, must strive to establish their right to call Prof. Nielsen himself a theologian. The opponent who has now appeared stands in the ranks of the former. He fights as a theologian for hearth and altar, without rancor or malice, but not without an eye for the openings his superior adversary presents. He does not succeed in proving what he had actually set as his aim, namely that theology still has vitality, and there may well be good reasons why such a proof was bound to fail; but he establishes beyond doubt that Prof. Nielsen cannot, from his standpoint, reject theology, even if a certain particular theology and a certain particular dogmatics have been exploded.

The author has one further merit. The natural reverence for Kierkegaard's memory has imposed silence about his works; they have been allowed to speak without any buzzing swarm of reasoners disturbing the impression of the mighty monologue. That this was right, every Dane will understand; a German would never grasp it, and Kierkegaard's Norwegian trumpeter, Mr. Dietrichson, perhaps least of all. But all the same, it was

the right thing. Yet a drawback has followed from it, namely a petrification of certain Kierkegaardian propositions in seemingly trustworthy interpretations. On such points, then, an inquiry into Kierkegaard's meaning must be set going, and in the essay on the Paradox Mr. Larsen has begun one.

But once these merits have been brought out, the best there is to say about the book has also been said. The author, in whom, despite a predominant independence, one can trace the influence of Jacobi and Schleiermacher, is lacking still, to some degree, in schooling, and to a high degree in dialectic. The first lack betrays itself, e.g., when at the end of his essay on conscience he demonstrates the impossibility of giving an objective proof of God's existence so thoroughly that in the same stroke he ends up demonstrating the impossibility of inferring from effect to cause at all; or when, in his somewhat layman-like feud with the idealists, he proves the existence of lifeless objects from the existence of the self-conscious being before this being has become conscious of itself. The lack shows itself above all in a sentence like this: "The miracle precisely confirms the law of nature; if one posits the exception, one must also posit the rule", in [10] which the expressions *law* and *rule*, just like the two famous sharks, swallow each other up to their hearts' content.

Of still greater significance is the lack of dialectic. The author speaks the language of philosophy, he uses its designations, he romps about with its expressions; but — the voice is not its voice. In every line one senses the theologian. The author's "Absolute" is — at times astonishingly — conceived undialectically, and why? Because in his mouth this expression does not designate the Idea of philosophy, but is merely a name, a hiding place, a mask behind which he seeks to make theology's representation of God unrecognizable. But since the designations of concepts react upon the train of thought, he not infrequently entangles himself in contradictions; at one moment, e.g., man is supposed not to differ in essence from the Absolute (the Eternal, the True), at another he is supposed not even to be able to comprehend the possibility of the Absolute's actions. When explanation now stands against explanation, philosophy's against theology's, the author takes up the following position. Since he is short of dialectical ability, the philosophical explanation becomes unintelligible to him; the miracle explanation, of course, does not even claim to be intelligible; and so it comes down to a choice between them. For this choice he then holds not reason but the heart responsible. That one will not accept the miracle explanation does not confuse him, then; that he understands perfectly well, for it rests on the hardening of hearts. Here Mr. Larsen casts aside his philosophical garb and shows himself in his theological vestments. Here, then, is also the limit of scientific discussion.

December 1865.

Postscript. In an article on Mr. Larsen's book in yesterday's *Dagbladet*, Mr. *Rudolf Schmidt* declares that it is not his intention "on this occasion" to clear up the obscurity in Professor Nielsen's doctrine mentioned above. This sad news is hereby conveyed to the readers of *Fædrelandet* as well.

[11]

Reply to Mr. Schmidt

(1866)

Besides an unsuccessful defense, Mr. Larsen's pamphlet contained an attack that carried the war into the adversary's own country. The cut was incomparably better than the parry; for a good cause arms eye and hand. In my Saturday article I endeavored to set the justification of the attack in a sharper light, and I held fast to this point as the main point; for it is on this that the interest rests. The battle against theology is of old date; *Feuerbach* and *Kierkegaard*, each from his own side, waged it with a force and consistency that have never since been attained; little weight now rests on that battle; but as surely as Professor *Nielsen's* philosophy is a far more significant and far more intelligent power than the theological science of our day, so surely does every doubt concerning it that is not plucked out of the air, and every thrust that does not strike the air, have a great and essential significance. But the matter deserves still greater attention when its point is a center, when the question is a vital question of the utmost importance and of pervasive influence; and this matter is of that kind. It is this that Mr. *Rudolf Schmidt* treats as a trifle.

Now if the contradiction I have pointed out had really been removed in any of Professor Nielsen's printed writings, then I would certainly be a greater charlatan in philosophy than any of the several that our fatherland possesses. But that is not how matters stand. Mr. Schmidt is kind enough to pay me a compliment on my philosophical cultivation, one that has a reference to *Grundideernes Logik* in tow. I have as little use for [12] the latter as for the former; I do not even understand what Mr. Schmidt had in mind with it. In the published part of *Grundideernes Logik* there is, apart from a few propositions put forward as bare assertions in the general introduction, nothing, absolutely nothing bearing on this matter, nor, given the nature of the design, could anything be found there. Only at the transition from the sphere of knowledge to that of power can the question come up, if in a form more remote from reality, and it can receive its proper answer only at the transition of the whole Logic into the philosophy of nature.

I did not expect enlightenment from Mr. Schmidt; I merely made fun of an expression of his. I have a well-founded doubt that a polemic with him would prove instructive, and shall therefore not engage in one; for what I want is to learn. But for that very reason an explanation on Prof. Nielsen's part would be of the highest value to me, and nothing would please me more than if he felt called upon to give one. For in this matter what we

need is not silence or reticence, but words that come from the liver and go to the heart,
unsparing candor, clarity, light:

Truth, like a torch, the more it's shook, it shines.

[13]

On Mr. Harald Høffding's
Polemic: Filosofi og Teologi
 [Philosophy and Theology]
 (1866)

When one reads through this work to make a passing acquaintance with the author's features, one receives an almost uncanny impression; for with single and double quotation marks ("goose-eyes," as Danish calls them) by the hundred — sometimes as many as thirty on a single page — the author, like an Argus of the goose tribe, stares gloomily out at the reader from the paper of the book. With him, that is, the quotations play the same role as the text of one's own making plays with other authors.

Proceeding from the assumption that the philosophical-theological controversy has in reality already been settled, Mr. *Høffding* is concerned only to make it clear that Prof. *Nielsen* is the one who has won; and it is to this end that he gives a heavy, densely packed restatement of the history of the battle, which, according to the reader's differing standpoint, is either insufficient or unnecessary. Against Mr. *Larsen's* pamphlet "Samvittighed og Videnskab" he then advances a number of arguments, mostly ones that have already been seen in print once before, and finally directs against the undersigned's earlier articles in *Fædrelandet* some objections which make up the weakest, but perhaps also the newest, part of the book. For these objections I am very grateful to the author; for they fully demonstrate what I have said before, namely how badly an explanation is needed from Prof. *Nielsen's* side.

[14] I have declared it a contradiction that Prof. *Nielsen* at one and the same time calls faith and knowledge absolutely heterogeneous principles and speaks of their reconciliation in human consciousness. Mr. *Høffding* teaches me that in Prof. *Nielsen's* view this reconciliation can take place, not *although*, but *because* these principles are absolutely heterogeneous. This is rather far from being any secret; but the contradiction is designated all the same by my "although." Is it conceivable that two absolutely heterogeneous principles can be reconciled in the same consciousness? Can it be shown that faith and knowledge are such principles? I answer these questions in the negative. It might, however, well be open to doubt whether two absolutely heterogeneous principles could hold sway in the human spirit without a split setting in by which the whole of existence would be cracked apart; and that Prof. *Nielsen* himself has not taken this absolute het-

erogeneity so very strictly is best proved, after all, by the circumstance that he speaks of conflict and reconciliation between those powers; for absolutely heterogeneous powers can neither wage war nor make peace with one another. But let us for once suppose that we have two absolutely heterogeneous principles before us: does Mr. Høffding not see, then, how strange all this talk becomes about how one is to place faith highest and science lowest, but not the reverse? Does he not see that every question of what is to be placed highest and what lowest would in that case become still more comical than *Poul Møller's* old one: Which is higher, a poplar-willow or a thunderclap? And yet many a poor student has perhaps come to grief when, at the examination drill, he answered wrongly and in his innocence turned faith and knowledge upside down.

To ease understanding, however, Mr. Høffding gives yet another hint. Ethics, philosophical ethics, “forms a transition between philosophy and religion.” Considered in and for itself, this proposition may be quite excellent; but in Mr. Høffding’s mouth it certainly cuts an incomparable figure. For morality has no doubt always been regarded as an admirable power; but that it could form the transition between two absolutely heterogeneous spheres—that is something hardly anyone has credited it with. Rather than investigate how this was supposed to come about, one is tempted to ask what moved Mr. Høffding to send this piece of cleverness out into the world. The answer is not difficult.

To anyone who has followed with an attentive eye the course of Professor *Nielsen's* rich activity as an author over the last decade, it has gradually become clear that, without taking back a single spoken word, he has, on the disputed point, if not changed, then [15] at least altered and softened his earlier view. I am far from imagining that I am saying anything disparaging by this. An avowal that one has changed one’s conviction from the ground up can be a noble, indeed an admirable, trait in an eminent personality, and such this act proved to be when Professor Nielsen in his time attached himself to Kierkegaard. To develop the same fundamental thought while adapting it is, if anything is, not merely an honest but an honorable thing. The latter, in my understanding, is what Professor Nielsen has done. In 1857 he declared that between the evangelical and the mythical there was no difference in the eyes of science; but in 1864 he softened this expression so that the superiority of religious ethics over the rational prevented science from declaring the Gospel a myth. The latter is indeed a hard saying; it is difficult to understand that there can be two kinds of morality, and that any other morality can be higher than the rational, i.e. the morality grounded in the rational cognition of man’s nature. But no matter: it is plain that a softening has taken place here; for with this the absolute

heterogeneity of faith and knowledge is at bottom given up, though not retracted.

For such things Mr. Høffding has no eye. A development which, despite the apparent protest of particular utterances, tends in the direction of raising science from the subordinate relation in which it was formerly placed—this he cannot see; instead he boldly heaps propositions torn loose from the most various books into a pile and stacks one contradiction on top of another. He lays it down that neither the right, nor the true, nor the good could hold its ground in real life if it were not supported by “religion”; but he is nonetheless convinced that there is a philosophical, hence rational, morality, which — on the assumption just mentioned — will at least have the less rational property that one cannot live by it. He maintains with the utmost zeal that the demands of conscience must not be asserted in science; but nonetheless, with the greatest unconcern, he reproaches the freethinkers’ science with being an “unbelieving” science. Mr. Høffding is no friend of consistency.

On the last page of the work the author raises the objection against me that, if I have found no contributions to an answer to my question in what has so far appeared of *Grun-*
 [16] *dideernes Logik*, then I ought not to have confined myself to wishing for enlightenment from Professor Nielsen, but should have found fault with what was given. This objection was easy to foresee and is easy to refute. It is, to be sure, incomprehensible to me how Professor Nielsen can let the possibility of miracle obtain a place in his system without running aground in final disunity; but in the part of the *Logik* that has appeared, no attempt whatsoever has been made at that either. Nor do I see how the development is to be able to give what the preface announces without the higher unity of knowledge and power, of ideality and reality, which is the fundamental thought of the work, being burst apart—most immediately by the idea of power turning into the representation of omnipotence in the theological sense. I alluded to this in an earlier article.

There are in this country, as elsewhere too, e.g. in France, certain authors who can best be likened to those well-known large bladders which are in themselves flat, slack and empty things, but which, with the help of inspiration from outside, swell up so that they take up quite a considerable space. It should be said to Mr. Høffding’s credit that he does not belong to this class. He evidently has an honest endeavor and a serious mind. But these merits have not prevented him, in his relation to Professor Nielsen, from showing himself on this occasion to be an all too loose-tongued child.

A Last Rejoinder

[17]

(1866)

Every theatergoer will have had the experience that even the bad actor can reap claps and applause when, as the knight of innocence or of faith, he pronounces a noble principle, and that the audience sometimes listens almost with displeasure as the actor defends a cause it considers bad. If my honored opponent, Mr. *Høffding*, could get the roles so distributed between us that he came to play an angel of light and I a demon of darkness, then his cause would undeniably have won, and outward triumph would have been assured him. Such a turn he tries to give the matter by accusing me of not wanting to be a party but a judge, of avowing a freethinking view not openly and honestly but only by roundabout ways, when after all “no one may take part in the contest without declaring what he bears on his shield.”

But this turn shall not succeed for him; it is not unbelief against faith, rather it is clarity against fog, that here stand face to face. For what is the object of the inquiry, what alone is being asked in this matter? Certainly not about *my* philosophy, any more than, e.g., about Mr. *Høffding*’s. There is only one single decisive point here which must be held fast, and it is this: Is Professor *Nielsen* in a contradiction when he calls faith and knowledge absolutely heterogeneous principles and yet lets them be reconciled in human consciousness, so that the one is placed highest, the other lowest, or is he not? He is; for either faith and knowledge are not absolutely heterogeneous, or they split consciousness completely; either they are not absolutely heterogeneous, or there can be no talk of a highest and a lowest. It is no use objecting, as Mr. *Høffding* does, that it is [18] after all the same human being who stands in a relation to both of the two absolutely heterogeneous principles; for the question is precisely whether man’s consciousness must not thereby be incurably divided. Nor does it help to say, as Mr. *Høffding* does, that for this very reason the question is put to each person individually how he will make his choice here. For what does the choice consist in? If the choice is between faith and knowledge on the one side and knowledge on the other, then whoever seizes the former chooses, after all, the split; if on the other hand the choice is between faith on the one side and knowledge on the other, then reconciliation in the same consciousness is, after all, given up, and only dualism, only disintegration, remains, even if it is shifted from the individual human being to mankind. It is of no use at all, like Per Degn, to answer

simple and clear questions with highly enigmatic and unintelligible talk.”)

I do not consider myself infallible, as Mr. Høffding gives his readers to understand; I do not even consider Professor Nielsen so, which Mr. Høffding would doubtless have forgiven me far more readily; but if I am not so immodest as to take it to be impossible that I can err, I am still far less so foolish that I should have set pen to paper, without a rock-firm confidence in the truth of my cause, against a man so highly gifted and so superior to me as Professor Nielsen. What I bear on my shield, then, is this: a conviction, full and firm, that every dualism (twofoldness) is impossible, and that in consequence Professor Nielsen’s doctrine on this point is untenable. What philosophy I have besides, or whether I have any at all, is quite as irrelevant to this question as what I think about the affairs of the Turks.

I have strengthened my argument by showing that Professor Nielsen himself has not been able to hold fast to the absolute heterogeneity. If it really obtained, then any [19] form of religious faith whatsoever would have to be compatible with Professor Nielsen’s philosophy. But if one asks, e.g.: can one at the same time be a Catholic and an adherent of Professor Nielsen’s doctrine? then the answer is Yes only on the condition that faith and knowledge have nothing whatever to do with each other, but No if account is to be taken of the ethics of Catholicism; for it is surely beyond doubt that this is not superior to the rational. In making the superiority of the ethics of religion the decisive thing, Professor Nielsen has given up his first standpoint. Since Mr. Høffding, however, believes that he can defend the proposition of the double ethics as a transition between philosophy and religion, I shall gladly follow the curious course of his thoughts.

There is, he says, an opposition between science and life. When the idea of the good is to be realized in deed, this opposition comes forward in such a way that rational ethics shows its insufficiency, and the necessity is seen — not of religious ethics, as one would provisionally have expected, but — of “religion.” Now I ask: what, then, is meant by religious ethics? Is it a science, or is it merely another name for the positive-religious? If it is the latter, why then the confusing designation? But if it is the former, then the matter is simple and the confusion plain. For then, by virtue of that very same opposition between science and life, this ethics too must become insufficient as soon as it is to be used in life, and recourse must again be had to something higher. But, not to mention that the significance of rational ethics, which was after all to be upheld, is by

⁹⁾So that Mr. Høffding shall not once more send my own turns of phrase back to me within the marks I will not name, and see it proved here into the bargain that I treat Professor Nielsen as a “delinquent,” I add that from this comparison it follows just as little that I am on the whole any Erasmus Montanus as that I have, like him, perpetrated the outrage “of striking Rasmus Nielsen 3 or 4 times on the back of the neck with clenched fists, all the while shouting: ‘Probe Majoren, probe Majoren!’” (Act 1, Scene 6).

this line of thought reduced to less than nothing, we get here a series of the scientific, the superscientific, the super-super-scientific, etc., which does not speak in favor of the logic of this defense. If being a moral human being involved such logical entanglements, then I do see that one would have to ask with Mr. Høffding: Can one at the same time be an ethical man and a man of science? But otherwise this question is not easy to understand. — No, it stands firm: if ethics makes the transition from philosophy to religion, then their absolute heterogeneity is given up, and the best proof of this doctrine's untenability is that Professor Nielsen has given it up not only here but, as I have shown, on other points as well. Thus, when the possibility of miracle is given a place in *Grundideernes Logik*.^{*)} For the difference between the Absolute of philosophy and the almighty God of theology is this, that the latter is not, like the Absolute, conditioned by its own conditions; but this difference the Logic abolishes in positing the possibility of miracle. In the Logic, then, the same doubling appears as in the ethics. Just as it cannot be understood how religious ethics can fail to have a retroactive and annihilating effect on the rational, so it cannot be conceived that the unconditioned personality, by virtue of its self-determination, can raise itself above its own self-determinations without their significance being annihilated, that is to say: without the laws of nature and of spirit, as we know them, becoming nothing, mere semblance. I understand that one can, with Kierkegaard, support one's paradoxical faith by rejecting science; but I do not comprehend how one can, like Professor Nielsen, give up doubt about science and yet keep that faith—at least not without being compelled to assert against the freethinker those demands of conscience which one will not tolerate the theologian's directing at oneself. This statement may perhaps explain to Mr. Høffding what he is so very interested in knowing, namely what it is that I recognize in Kierkegaard. Only people of very little independence, surely, understand by recognition nothing but a plain and simple adherence through thick and thin. What I admire in Kierkegaard is, among much else, his consistency with himself. [20]

This is my last word to Mr. Høffding. Now nothing, to be sure, is further from my mind than to conclude from Professor Nielsen's silence that he will endorse what my opponents have asserted against me, or that their contributions really contain the correct

^{*)}I was first informed that the solution of the problem was given in the part of the *Logik* that had appeared. I replied that it was not to be found there and, given the plan of the work, could not be found there. The same people who picture faith and knowledge shut off in two different compartments of consciousness then accused me of subscribing to a pigeonhole philosophy. I replied that I understood the fundamental thought of the work to mean that the possibility of miracle could not be prepared for or derived, but could come about only by a leap. Now Mr. Høffding does not refrain from reproaching me for not having pointed out the error in what has already appeared—an error which I myself declare is not to be found there.

interpretation of his view; but I believe that it would have served the cause if he had
[21] made this known. A tangible result a contest of ideas like this one could not bring; but it
is my hope that, if my statements have yielded nothing else, they have at least perhaps
made one or another who strives in quiet—one who has the courage to judge, the will to
judge honestly, the understanding to judge rightly—aware of where the difficulty lies.

On Self-Responsibility

[22]

(1866)

The author of “Julen hos Elise” has brought out, with Gad’s publishing house, a work, “*Om Selvansvarlighed*”, which may serve as an example to illustrate the following sentence in “*Enten—Eller*”: “There is a kind of reasoning chatter which in its endlessness stands in the same relation to the result as the interminable lines of Egyptian kings to the historical yield.” For these words give the right point of view for a book which, like this one, is without force in its expression and without movement in its thoughts, boneless in its structure, jointless in its articulation and bloodless in its execution.

The author has set himself the laudable aim of being generally comprehensible, but he has not seen that comprehensibility is attained far better by a discipline of thought that excludes foggy breadth, irrelevant digressions, repetitions and triviality than by any of these scarcely brilliant vices themselves; he has further followed the laudable plan of leaving all earlier works on this subject unmentioned; but it almost seems as though he had also himself either not read them or not understood them; for otherwise it is incomprehensible that he has not even been able to *pose* his problem with any precision, even if he could neither solve it nor cut it through. His work, then, belongs as little among those that make the results of a science clear to the great multitude as among those that carry literature forward; it ought not to have been published as an independent book; in abridged form it could have claimed a place in one of our two theological journals.

The fundamental mood of the book is a deep sense of the inadequacy of our faculties to solve the riddles of existence. The author always begins by theologically shrouding [23] matters in mystery, only to declare them inexplicable afterwards. Of *conscience*, for example, it is said that although it must stand in a continuous connection with the all-governing principle, it is “*entirely inexplicable* how the connection takes place and is maintained”; of *life* we are told that the vital force (!) makes itself known only when it is joined (!) with a bodily existence, “but how the vital force joins itself with the bodily in such a way that this can reproduce itself in a new individual is the *Unfathomable*.” Sometimes he presupposes degrees of intelligibility within this Unfathomable, as when in the following sentence he arbitrates between theism and pantheism: “If the first origin and the entire activity of a living, rational, personal being as almighty God is *incomprehensible*, then the origin and productive power of an impersonal fundamental

force is no less so; but the life of the world, its purpose and goal, becomes *nevertheless more intelligible* when it is regarded as proceeding from a personal God." Sometimes, on the other hand, he gives up the struggle altogether, as in the following despondent, naive declaration, though a natural one in the author's mouth: "we confess that we can never attain any clarity in our thought about the things that cannot be presented to our senses."

To gain a foothold in this darkness the author now sometimes starts from theological presuppositions, such as that of an original state of morality which was later lost, or that of original sin; sometimes he appeals, as his first presupposition, to our *feeling*: positive religion is confirmed by "our own inner feeling" or by "the involuntary feelings of a purer human nature," and an opposing view, which admittedly "may well have something in its favor in what we experience by way of the senses about the course of development the world has passed through" [that is, in the one thing about which, in the author's opinion, we can attain clarity], is refuted by the fact that "there is nothing in it that can appeal to human feeling." Once this criterion of truth has been adopted, woe then to the doctrine of infusoria and trichinae; for truly these creatures have nothing about them that appeals to human feeling.

On the foundation now indicated, the relation between faith and knowledge is determined as follows: "The one is won by a practical path, through experience, by consideration of the visible, which can be observed by all; therefore the representation [24] of it can also be compared with, and corrected by, the representation others have formed of it, and attain such certainty that we can designate it as *knowledge*. The representation of the higher (!) spiritual, on the other hand, becomes of a more (!) subjective nature, because it has nothing visible to attach itself to that is observable by all in the same way; we designate it as *faith*." By this fine and precise definition of concepts, logic and thoroughness, among other things, become faith; but with all the amiable unselfconsciousness of a young modern lady the author is sure of being understood when he hangs faith upon the capacious comparative that goes by the name of "the higher."

The author is as great a stylist as he is a philosopher. In the first capacity we see him when he teaches that "many passions and affects can arise and persist only with *bodily support*, such as irascibility and a propensity to debauchery" (it takes a body), or when he speaks of how the human body "expands from a most insignificant beginning constantly in greater and greater compass." As a thinker we hear him in the following priceless derivation of the love of honor: "The beautiful body arouses admiration, but only the human body can call forth honor; for it is the spirit alone that, as the possessor

of this body, becomes the object of it. It is chiefly the spiritual expression, which makes itself known most immediately in the features of the face, that can call forth honor. But the expression is uncertain and cannot in everyone penetrate the corporeality; therefore [ergo] man must seek to win honor by his actions." Holberg's Henrik never conducted a proof more wittily.

In the book's seventh section, "The Relation between Human Freedom and God's Governance," the author has concentrated the results of his research and his whole confusion. This section justifies the Deity. The reasoning is as follows: The governance that reaches its goal while preserving the freedom of the persons it uses as means must be regarded as the most perfect. Consequently man's freedom does not conflict with the perfection of the governance. Since, however, a development proceeding by virtue of freedom cannot in every particular accord with the divine will, the question arises whether it would not have been most worthy of the governance to cancel the evil effects of freedom, often calamitous for the innocent, by an extraordinary intervention, by the miracle. The author denies this. Why? His manner of reasoning is worth hearing: "If [25] the shot aimed at the innocent man's breast glanced off it without harming him, the result could stand as a testimony to his innocence, but it would not cast any light on the act committed; the act could be set up as a test of the nature of the one against whom it was directed; it would not serve toward a better cognition of the good or the bad in the intention that led to the act." How such a cognition of the moral character of the intention is to be derived from the outcome, we leave it to the author to prove; and merely to be sure we understand him, we put this question to him: Is there, then, no miracle, nothing supernatural?

One must surely be astonished that a theological philosopher as well brought up as the author seems ready to answer with a flat denial. But let the reader be reassured: he does not do that either; in philosophy he forms himself on the best models. He holds with Salomon Goldkalb "vieles for und bag, und ja und nej tillige": "If we see no reason to assume such breaches of the natural order and law as necessary for the completion of God's plan for the world, this nevertheless does not exclude a divine activity that must stand as supernatural for man. Such there must be; for without it the power laid down in creation could not be maintained (!). God's activity as sustainer of the world is supernatural in so far as it is *incomprehensible* to the human faculties, but it becomes no less natural when it expresses itself, while holding fast to definite laws, through a *higher* nature." Crafty author! There at a single stroke he found a use for his *Incomprehensible* and his *Higher*, and indeed got the two fused together into a higher incomprehensibility.

As one among many testimonies to the theological-philosophical quagmire in which we are stuck here in Denmark at present, this book is not wholly without interest. But for the rest we know no better advice to offer its author than that contained in this old couplet from *Peder Paars*:

Your finger in the times you must stick, and smell
what time you're living in, if you would heed me well.

Claudius Wilckens: Nationalitetsideens Gyldighed

[26]

[The Validity of the Idea of Nationality]

(1867)

Against a treatise by Dean Kofoed-Hansen, *Nationalitet og Kristendom*, the author stresses that the question of the justification of the idea of nationality vis-à-vis Christianity is only a single side of the question of the justification of human culture as such, so that one cannot deny that idea significance and validity without passing sentence on the whole of culture. To that extent Mr. Wilckens may well be entirely right.

But when he now goes on to set forth his own conception of the relation between Christianity and humanity, his view is even more unclear and self-contradictory than his opponent's. From the standpoint of philosophy he proclaims — seemingly without properly knowing the meaning of the word he uses — an unconditional *dualism* of divine history and human history, of religious development and human development, of Providence and world-governance. But dualism (fundamental cleavage) is the private shame of scientific thinking, which the thinker himself ought surely to be the last to put on display. Although the author himself declares that eternal Providence *set* the world-governance to rule over the destiny of the nations, he stresses in spaced type that world history, guided by the world-governance, has *nothing, absolutely nothing* to do with Providence, and Providence *nothing, absolutely nothing* to do with it.

This is already going very far; but the author draws the bow tighter still when, reproaching Dean Kofoed-Hansen for lacking even the faintest inkling of the said remarkable dualism, he accuses him of being in the grip of the same fundamental error that in the Middle Ages brought mankind to establish *duæ veritates*. For who has two [27] truths, if not Mr. Wilckens?

In this doctrine of the relation of truth the author attaches himself very closely to Professor R. Nielsen. When he occasionally designates his view (thus, e.g., the curious proposition that “God set the laws of nature to bear witness against himself”) as an “individual explanation,” the meaning of this is perhaps that, though not in such particular points, yet in what he otherwise puts forward, he regards himself as the organ of Professor Nielsen's teachings. If he is right in this, then what Holberg says in *Niels Klim*: applies to Denmark now: “There are a number of the learned men of Europe who cultivate both theology and philosophy with equal zeal; as philosophers they doubt all things, as theologians, on the other hand, they dare deny nothing.”

P. S. V. Heegaard: Indledning til den rationelle Etik

[28]

[Introduction to Rational Ethics]

(1867)

In the wider sense of the word *introduction*, any preparatory course through which an author leads his readers into a science may be called an introduction to it. Both a history of ethics and a history of morality could, e.g., provide a preparation for the study of the science of the good. But of such propaedeutics there is, for any doctrine whatever, only one that is indispensable, namely the one that has the doctrine itself as its object. The introduction to ethics that is not arbitrarily chosen but necessarily required answers the question: What is ethics? The proper problem of ethics itself is: What is the good? Since the author, immediately after establishing the concept of ethics, proceeds to develop the essence of the good, he has given no introduction in the narrower and proper sense.

But, one might say, never mind the name: what does the book offer? To this the answer is that Dr. Heegaard, who takes no account of chronological order, has not wished to give a history of ethics; he has wished only to use particulars of history to illustrate the various possible ethical principles. To derive these is the task of his work. Since the principle of division that is laid down, namely the opposition between the objective and the subjective, is, however, an opposition that shows itself in every idea and not merely in the ethical one, the good is not considered according to its peculiar essence, but only from its general logical side; the specifically moral concepts, such as duty, virtue, conscience, serve by the plan only to illustrate the said opposition, so their ethical peculiarity does not come out, and like the fundamental opposition, so too the one between actuality and essentiality and the one between immediacy and reflection, on which the subdivision rests, are purely metaphysical. [29]

But, one might say, here after all is a principle of division; if only *that* is held fast, one ought not to take the author further to task. Unfortunately it is dropped as quickly as it is set up. The ethics of essentiality is not subdivided, subjective ethics is not divided at all, and yet there was absolutely nothing to prevent the chosen points of view from being applied. Even if there were not historical representatives for all the forms — which, however, can easily be found — the cognition of principles, on which the author lays so much weight, required that they at least all be set out.

Still, Dr. Heegaard perhaps wishes the reader to concede that it matters less whether the principle of subdivision changes, provided only the principle of the main division is

held fast. We therefore turn our attention to this. But it is surely clear that if subjective-objective ethics is to be the third member in the series, it cannot have forms under it that are again declared to be one-sidedly subjective, like Kierkegaard's ethics. That it nonetheless has them is intelligible only from the fact that the author has here changed his principle of division altogether. The historical phenomena presented in the third section are found together not because their ethics bears a subjective-objective stamp, which on the whole it does not, but because, in contrast to the preceding ones, they take up a decisive relation to the Christian-religious.

This is not felicitous, but let it be! We will follow the author without dispute here too, and merely test what forms must arise when both the rational and the positive-religious are given as presuppositions. One can then — to use the author's expression: faith and knowledge — either reject faith for the sake of knowledge (like Feuerbach) or, conversely, knowledge in favor of faith (like Kierkegaard), or one can assert the validity of both, and then either in unity (like theology) or in unconditional separation (like Nielsen). Of these forms Dr. Heegaard skips theological ethics entirely: an ethicist such as Schleiermacher is not included, whereas Nielsen, who has written no ethics at all, is treated at great length.

[30] Should the author now say that theological ethics is too insignificant to be included, this will be no reason in his mouth, since as the representative of one of the forms he has set up Feuerbach, of whom he himself remarks that he has no ethical principle. Should he say that theological ethics is a form that no rational person need take into account, he must remember that the question is still undecided whether the same cannot be said of the tendency that would hold faith and knowledge in absolute heterogeneity. In any case theological ethics cannot be rejected except through a critique; to shut the door on it is a way out, but not a scientific one.

The new principle of division was the opposition between the rational and the positive-religious, the latter of which Dr. Heegaard stubbornly treats as synonymous with the religious in general, just as if there were only one positive religion in one single confession. But where does the religious come from that drops like a bomb into the book's conclusion? Is it enough for a cognition of principles that we do not mistake subjective for objective, religious for rational, without these concepts being seen in the least as determinations of principle, as utterances of one and the same being? The author says merely that revealed religion is manifestly a spiritual power. But what does that prove? For the cognition of principles hardly much.

And what does it prove that the author calls the religious an ambiguous determination, since it can be taken both in a rational and in an anti-rational sense; for where does the

anti-rational come from? Why, it comes from revelation. And revelation? Why, it is simply there. But is it therefore anti-rational? Surely there is so much thought and reason in the Old and New Testaments that it at least holds its own against the miraculous. If one wants to draw the religious into the development as a definite positive form of religion, one must accept the consequences and at the same time draw it into the investigation. If one will not do this, but proceeds from it in an entirely immediate way, then let it be done properly, and let us have a catechism! That is incomparably easier than these intricate expositions, which after all can only assert, not demonstrate. But here the dualism has broken out that is now pressing hard into our philosophical condition, and that shows this condition to be neither more nor less than a crisis. It weakens the religious, which, as unconditionally contrary to reason, becomes an impotent spiritual force, and it weakens [31] the commands of reason, which are robbed of their deepest elements in order to transfer these to the anti-rational, which means little else than to shelve them. A so-called rational ethics that cannot and dares not treat in its own way the ethical questions that every revelation treats in its own way is without generative power and of no significance; at most it becomes an ethics that “can be applied in civil society and the state as they are in reality,” but not by a person in whom the ethical, in whatever form, stirs with vigor.

The older principle of division is brought by the author into connection with the new one by designating subjective-objective ethics as the one that is conscious that it is theory and not practice, whereas the representatives of merely objective and merely subjective ethics are said to be caught in the illusion that theory and practice simply coincide — a strong expression indeed, when one recalls that among those who thus err are thinkers such as Kant and Fichte. But to this new opposition of theory and practice, this third principle of division, which like the second drops from heaven at the end of the book, not the slightest attention has been paid in what went before. One must, then, think the earlier forms through again from this point of view and so do the work the author ought to have done. He says himself that from this point of view one has greater sympathy for Aristotle, the Stoics and the Epicureans than for Hegel and Fichte, but why merely sympathy? The whole arrangement becomes a different one; Hegel and Aristotle no longer come into the same class at all. On the relation between the two principles of division that appeared last, moreover, Dr. Heegaard does not express himself with any clarity at all; one sees, to be sure, that practical ethics can be both rational and religious; but for the former there appears no independent representative; it is found only as a stage of development under R. Nielsen.

The author has thus really wanted to view the ethical forms under a threefold point

of view, namely partly according to the opposition subjective-objective, partly according to that of rational-religious, and partly according to that of theoretical-practical. With this, however, three principles of division have been set up. Now however unclear the articulation might be, these three could nevertheless very well have been united by virtue of dialectic. Under each of them all the forms would have had to be capable of
 [32] being placed; they would have had to interpenetrate at every point. It ought to have been shown how the subjective is the objective, that both are the religious, both the existential, the existential the theoretical, etc., until the whole cycle had been set in motion. Then the author could have made his distinctions with a clear conscience. As it is, the forms bristle outward away from one another without inner coherence, without any dialectic at all, and yet the author's standpoint is the dialectical one, so dialectical that he even — something at which Kierkegaard would marvel — lets the very boundary between the rational and the anti-rational be of a dialectical nature.

One question forces itself upon us in conclusion, a very important one, namely this: Does the author himself have any standpoint? Because he, e.g., presents Feuerbach as a rational-atheistic ethicist who has no ethics, it does not of course follow that the author is one. And because R. Nielsen is presented as the one who gives a religious and rational ethics, one still cannot presuppose it to be the author's assumption that such an ethics has validity.

What would have to show this is missing, namely a critique of Nielsen's view. For the remarkable fact is that when the author comes to the points that, as the decisive ones, demanded a critique in the highest degree, he very modestly closes his critical knife, the one he has used so vigorously and bravely in what went before. Professor Nielsen is beyond comparison the most significant representative in the whole last class, and the author has him play a strange role. He is the representative of a distinct form, but as such he is representative of representatives of other forms that have been given no voice of their own, e.g., of the rational-religious. Further, he is a critique of the whole and so also of himself, and finally he is the chief representative of ethics, although he has written no ethics.

What would one say if an art critic were lecturing on a sculptural group rich in figures and, after giving his judgment of the less important figures, vanished when he came to judge the principal figure, which cast the real light over the whole? Could he excuse himself by saying that the principal figure had to speak for itself and that he would say nothing but what the principal figure clearly said? No, then he might have spared himself the whole lecture; for if his listeners are able to judge the principal figure,

they can also judge the whole group. Either one gives a lecture, and then one gives it to [33] the end, or one leaves it to others to work the matter out for themselves, and then there is no lecture at all.

If, then, it is Heegaard's opinion that Nielsen's standpoint is his own, he must say so; it must not be a matter about which one knows anything only from a more or less reliable quarter. What view underlies the critique is at present a secret. Only this is certain: if the author has no other standpoint than Professor Nielsen's, then it is just as strange to see R. Nielsen's name among those of the other thinkers as it would be to see the author's own; if, on the other hand, he is not at one with Professor Nielsen, he has hardly shown great independence or self-reliance by leaving the latter's view unjudged.

[34]

Rejoinder to Dr. P. S. V. Heegaard

(1867)

In an anticritique whose tone is by no means justified by the tone of the review against which it is directed, Dr. P. S. V. Heegaard has not disdained to make use of the old trick with which a man who, in an intellectual contest, has good reasons for not wanting a reply sometimes tries to gag his opponent, and whose recipe runs as follows: "Should Mr. N. N. now, as would be just like him, feel an urge to have the last word, he is free to do so, etc.", which, being interpreted, means: "Since for my part I have no other defense than to put forward denials and to throw out accusations that cannot stand a moment longer than it takes a reply to arrive, I feel a heartfelt urge to cut my opponent off, if at all possible."

Now, though it pains me not to be able to satisfy so deeply felt an urge, I nonetheless beg the Doctor to be assured that I fully understand and appreciate it. It is quite understandable that Dr. Heegaard, feted and acclaimed by such expert judges as those he has found in *Illustreret Tidende* and *Berlingske*, should himself have begun to regard his work as good and thorough, and that it should have been an unpleasant surprise to him to meet a critic who was of the opposite opinion; but he ought to have taken this fact more calmly; he ought to have made an effort to grasp the line of thought in my article, at least where it lies right under his nose, and he would then not have stopped in the middle of reading a compound sentence to lament the meaninglessness of its first half.

[35]

Here is an example of how the Doctor has read. My review contained the following words: "A question forces itself upon us: Does the author himself have any standpoint? Because he, e.g., presents Feuerbach as a rational-atheistic ethicist who has no ethics, it does not of course follow that the author is one. And because R. Nielsen is presented as the one who gives a religious and rational ethics, one still cannot presuppose it to be the author's assumption that such an ethics has validity."

Dr. Heegaard now tears the one sentence about Feuerbach out of its context, cannot grasp the point of this statement, since no reasonable person could think of reasoning in that way, and cries: "To what purpose, then, the remark?" Now, if my honored opponent really was unable, in a calm state of mind, to see what purpose this remark serves, it would be in vain for me to try to explain the matter to him; and it is only because, while writing down his piece, he was evidently in a state of muddled irascibility that I spoon-feed him the necessary enlightenment: the two cases set out (that of Feuerbach

and that of Nielsen) are of the same kind; if nothing can be inferred from the first, then nothing can be inferred from the second either, and consequently it is left unexplained in the book itself whether the author is *with* Professor Nielsen or *against* Professor Nielsen, or whether he has no opinion at all.

In his book the Doctor showed himself an accomplished diplomat, took careful care not to hint at any independent view, and performed the egg dance of departing from Professor Nielsen on no point whatever, without, however, hinting by so much as a syllable at any agreement with him; in short, he conducted himself as a cautious man.

Now caution is no doubt a priceless virtue, a burgomaster's virtue, as they say — and who knows whether Dr. Heegaard has not mistaken the calling of his virtues by insisting on being a philosopher! — but there do occur cases here in life in which one must sacrifice it. It needs only someone to prove so importunate as to ask whether the Doctor, who “is in on” the development of others, has then no development of his own at all, and he is forced to confess that he has so far never thought of anything but the old thing, swearing by the master's words; indeed, he affects to be almost offended at the suspicion that he himself might have a view, and derives his receptiveness toward Professor Nielsen “simply” from the fact that one does not criticize the standpoint on [36] which one stands oneself³⁾. But where in the world was I supposed to learn anything about Dr. Heegaard's standpoint, when the only road to it ran through an inference of which the Doctor himself (rashly) declares that no reasonable person could think of drawing it?

No, the Doctor's newspaper article supplies a piece of information of which his book gives not the slightest hint, and in imparting it Dr. Heegaard has exchanged his arrogance for a modesty without equal. Far be it from me to accuse my opponent of “straining for effect”; but might not the modesty he has here displayed produce its effect all the same? Might not many a father or guardian say to his ward: “O my son! Look at yourself in the mirror of this mature man! Though no longer quite young, though a Doctor of Philosophy and a Privatdocent, though the author of a book that inspires awe by its thickness alone, he is still so modest as to have no other opinion than the one his teacher has.” Oh, surely the Doctor, without having intended it, will achieve such an effect, and his modesty will propagate itself from generation to generation.

³⁾Dr. Heegaard speaks of “being in on the development” much as the Cat and the Hen in Andersen speak of purring and laying eggs. He seems to think that one must, as a *studiosus perpetuus*, have heard all of Professor Nielsen's lectures, those for the freshmen and those for the educated as well, if one is to be allowed to join in the talk about philosophical subjects here at home. Indeed, he even invites me — not without wit — to check whether he has correctly reproduced Professor Nielsen's line of thought from lectures that have as yet been neither delivered nor printed.

Now modesty is no doubt an inestimable virtue, in some people's opinion even the finest in a young man, but there are nonetheless cases here in life in which an expression of modesty becomes one and the same thing as a declaration of bankruptcy. The Doctor is in a great and lamentable error when he thinks that one does need a standpoint of one's own to write an ethics but by no means to write an introduction to one, and in another error just as great when he supposes that my complaint about his lack of a standpoint has its ground in a confusion of the introduction to ethics with ethics itself.

[37] Dr. Heegaard is bold enough to reject my definition of what an introduction to ethics means with a simple: This is incorrect. We shall see with what right. It is already peculiar that my opponent should insist on one particular explanation of the title of his book, just as if "Introduction to Ethics" were a name for a science current and accepted among men of science. But it is still more peculiar that so cautious an author is not more cautious with the definition of the concept that he gives. When he says that one cannot develop what ethics is without explaining what the Good is, this is self-evident, understood absolutely; but taken relatively it is wrong, for if no distinction is made between the science of a science and that science itself, the system of the sciences turns into an even and uniform fog. And when he holds that the introduction to ethics ought to consist in the metaphysics of ethics, he runs aground on the following dilemma: either he gets a general metaphysics, one that falls outside that of the particular sciences, which is nonsense, or he is compelled to admit that the metaphysics of the special discipline is not an independent science but must consist of propositions borrowed from general metaphysics. And that is really how matters stand; that is why, e.g., the metaphysics of the beautiful has never been set up as a separate science either. The most amusing thing, however, is that Dr. Heegaard, by virtue of his way of seeing things, must consistently demand metaphysics itself as philosophical propaedeutics, whereby he comes into conflict partly with common sense, which is of lesser importance here, and partly with his own oracle, Professor Nielsen, who, in agreement with my conception, defines propaedeutics as the science that answers the question: "What is philosophy?"

But I will make Dr. Heegaard a present of his bold assertions on this point; let him define the introduction as he pleases, this much still stands unshaken: whatever an introduction may be, it must be an organic component of the system to which it leads and by which it is comprehended, and then the same life, the same spirit, the same principle must also pulse in the introduction as in the system, and a lack of principle must be just as reprehensible in the former as in the latter. How, then, can so modest a man as Dr. Heegaard believe that, with his modest lack of a standpoint, he is fit to write

the introduction?

Or does Dr. Heegaard perhaps have a principle after all, a principle without a standpoint? What, then, has he set against my specific demonstration of his spineless wavering between three different principles of division? Not a word, not a letter! Bold as he otherwise is at denying, here he fails to hear the criticism, and is wise to do so. And is his talk about the subdivision perhaps more successful than his silence about the main point? Can anything more preposterous be imagined than that the Doctor should call on *me* to show what compelling reason there is to subdivide the ethics of essentiality, i.e., to break the phenomenon on the very wheel on which he himself has laid it? [38]

I answer: If there lies in the concept of actuality a compelling reason for subdivision into “immediate” and “reflected” — and the Doctor must surely assume so, since he divides in that way — then such a reason must also lie in essentiality. For in the opposite case those two determinations would, of course, fall outside the latter — a fine ontology. The emphasis lies on what is a matter of principle, on the whole of all the determinations of principle employed, which must form a unity. If the historical material does not correspond, so much the worse for the Doctor. It is he, not I, who has to make the material and the principles essentially coincide; it is he who has registered, having been unable to show the transition between the historical and what is a matter of principle, and he will hardly succeed in making up for his short weight with the ingenuous declaration that he “has not, after all, given so little in the way of development of principles.” It does not become any more certain because he himself assures us of it.

But then Dr. Heegaard has, of course, declared that a criticism of his work which, like mine, does not take up all the questions afresh from the beginning and does not carry out the insurmountable task of putting the correct in the place of the supposedly incorrect — such a criticism “is not worth heeding,” and this pronouncement may have made an impression on one or two. But how can an author who by his own admission has a view of the whole only at second hand demand of a newspaper review of two and a half columns so much more than he himself has given in four hundred and fifty pages? The reviewer has supplied nothing but assertions, he says, without proof. That is only half true, but let it be so! Against these he sets other assertions, at least as unproved, apparently, to be sure, without being aware that he offers nothing more. [39]

But then the question still remains which assertions the thinking reader of the book is compelled to grant, his or mine, and I confidently leave it to those who know the subject to judge between us.

[40]

R. Nielsen: Grundideernes Logik

[The Logic of the Fundamental Ideas]

To give an idea of the line of thought in *Professor R. Nielsen's "Grundideernes Logik, 2den Del"* in a couple of words cannot be done. To deliver a criticism would be more difficult still. But this much shall simply be said: it would be a disgrace to our fatherland if a work such as this did not find numerous buyers among the large public that consists of the older or younger pupils of the excellent university teacher and writer to whom it is due. The volume most recently published is written with a logical virtuosity, a sharpness and definiteness of expression, an omnipresent liveliness and flight in the presentation, that must awaken the strongest admiration and that make the reading as attractive as it is instructive. Even the reader who is comparatively unfamiliar with investigations of this kind will find large sections that treat, in a manner generally intelligible and at the same time new, original and full of genius, problems to which ordinary reasoning constantly returns and which it is never able to solve by its own powers. Such are, e.g., the questions of the origin and meaning of languages, of the necessity of the Word as the expression of the divine thoughts, of God's foreknowledge and omniscience, of the creation of the world, of pre-existence, etc. The work is shot through with a struggle, testifying to an unmistakable superiority, against Madvig, against Sibbern, against Martensen and others as representatives of one-sided or antiquated points of view, and with attacks, launched from new standpoints, on thinkers of the past such as Kant and Hume, attacks that cast a peculiar light on the merits and the errors of these men.

[41]

Since this place is so little suited to a critical pronouncement, we shall permit ourselves a remark on only one quite single point. Since *Grundideernes Logik* has not, in Professor Nielsen's treatment, become a strictly delimited science, and since the author shows a pervasive endeavor to take in as much as possible of the given religious content of representation, intimations crop up here and there of the author's well-known views on the boundaries of the domain of reason against the religious, although the work as yet bears only faint traces of the monstrous doctrines that Dr. Heegaard in his latest writing has presented as belonging to Professor Nielsen. The cornerstone of this whole doctrine, however, is the Kierkegaardian conception of "the Paradox," and if only one could succeed in showing to what desperate, indeed insane, consequences adherence to this standpoint must necessarily lead, then there is hope that the whole building erected upon it will collapse without further criticism. But a point of attachment for such an

attempt the author of the Logic has himself provided. In seeking to show that the Kantian category *the thing in itself* is a mere phantom of mist, he conducts the proof as follows: “Kant cannot avoid passing a judgment on the *thing in itself*. He must say of it that it *is*. But once it has been proved that the category of the understanding, *being*, must be determining for the *thing in itself*, then the same holds of all the other categories.”

Nothing can be clearer or more correct than this line of thought. But how, then, is it possible that the brilliant author of *Grundideernes Logik* can fail to see that this very same line of proof can be applied against the concept “the Paradoxical,” which he has nevertheless solemnly declared legitimate. The philosopher of the absurd may writhe as much as he likes; he must still confess that, if he can say nothing else about the Paradox, this impenetrable, incomprehensible thing, he must at least establish of it that it *is*. But being is a determination of reason. And if “the Paradox” now belongs to a circle within which the concept “being” is valid, then it also belongs to a circle within which all the determinations of reason are valid. But what does this imply? Nothing less than the flagrant contradiction that the Paradoxical, as subject, receives nothing but predicates determined by reason. If one wishes to avoid it, there is no other way out than to fall silent, i.e., not merely to shut oneself up in an isolation in which, although one cannot immediately communicate oneself to others, one nonetheless understands oneself — but [42] to fall silent unconditionally, to become dumb as the fish is dumb, to cease to be a human being. This is the dilemma. If one holds fast to “the Paradoxical,” one will gradually find oneself carpentering together a system like the Ptolemaic system of astronomy, in which the first false conjecture could only ever be upheld by others just as desperate, in the same way as the paradox that conflicts with reason has already made a “rational paradox” (!) necessary. But then, too, one fine day the clear Copernican system of reason will stand victorious without any struggle, solely by the all-conquering power that lies in the holy simplicity of the true.
